SAN MIGUEL COUNTY
Housing Code Update

Overall Themes

Following the October SSR meeting and three days of stakeholder discussions in San Miguel County, this memo summarizes high-level themes, ideas, and recommendations heard for the San Miguel County Housing Code Update project. Approximately **54** individuals were directly engaged for this first round of listening sessions, not including meetings with County staff and elected officials. A feedback survey and opportunity for continued 1-1 meetings with the project team is currently open through the first week of November 2025.

Key Themes from Community Conversations:

- Strong recognition that housing is a critical challenge affecting workforce, families, and economic vitality
- Concerns about traffic and infrastructure capacity, particularly water availability in key areas
- Desire to clarify regional roles and responsibilities between County and municipalities
- Interest in learning from other mountain communities' experiences (considering geographic constraints, wildfire mitigation in the WUI, water conservation, and open space preservation)
- Desire to maintain community character while addressing housing needs near existing infrastructure and services

Regional Differences:

- East End (Telluride / Mountain Village): Frustration over limited workforce housing progress; skepticism about CH zone; concern about density, water, and growth pressure.
- West End (Norwood, Placerville, Wright's Mesa): Feeling like they're being asked to absorb growth driven by the East End; focus on infrastructure limitations and maintaining agricultural character.

Feedback on Code Mechanics and Structure:

- Difficult or impossible to build any missing middle housing types in county without going through PUD process
- Need for clarity and predictability in the review process.

- Desire for a minor subdivision or small-scale process for missing middle housing (such as cottage homes and ADUs).
- Confusion around CH zone purpose, criteria, and process (perception of excessive density at 20 du/acre).
- Inconsistent or unclear mitigation fee structure.
- Perceived gaps in how the code treats ADUs, deed restrictions, and well/septic limits.
- Interest in a density bonus and/or other developer incentives to build affordable workforce housing, rather than restrictions.

Other Ideas for Housing Action Planning *(outside the scope of the San Miguel County Housing Code Update)*

- *Financial Incentives*: Interest in affordable housing mitigation fee adjustments, fee waivers, property tax reductions for deed-restricted units, and Transfer of Development Rights (TDR) options within HOAs.
- *Programmatic*: Desire for rebate or incentive programs, especially for ADUs (similar to Durango ADU rebate, Vail's Lease to Locals, InDeed), temporary or seasonal housing solutions with dedicated spaces for people working in the county while living in campers/vans/rvs, programs to repair / rehabilitate substandard housing, programs to preserve existing housing stock.
- *Revenue generation*: Interest in exploring transfer fees tied to sales tax, "empty homes" tax, potentially an airport landing fee.
- *Public-private partnerships:* Developers willing to partner if process were clearer; potential for HOA participation in affordable housing delivery; interest in expanding projects financed through LIHTC; interest in employer-assisted housing programs and projects.